Daily Bible Note

Date: 2026-11-01

I. Today's Reading

NKJV: Philemon 1:1-14

1 Paul, a prisoner of Christ Jesus, and Timothy our brother, To Philemon our beloved friend and fellow laborer,

2 to the beloved Apphia, Archippus our fellow soldier, and to the church in your house:

3 Grace to you and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.

4 I thank my God, making mention of you always in my prayers,

5 hearing of your love and faith which you have toward the Lord Jesus and toward all the saints,

6 that the sharing of your faith may become effective by the acknowledgment of every good thing which is in you in Christ Jesus.

7 For we have great joy and consolation in your love, because the hearts of the saints have been refreshed by you, brother.

8 Therefore, though I might be very bold in Christ to command you what is fitting,

9 yet for love's sake I rather appeal to you—being such a one as Paul, the aged, and now also a prisoner of Jesus Christ—

10 I appeal to you for my son Onesimus, whom I have begotten while in my chains,

11 who once was unprofitable to you, but now is profitable to you and to me.

12 I am sending him back. You therefore receive him, that is, my own heart,

13 whom I wished to keep with me, that on your behalf he might minister to me in my chains for the gospel.

14 But without your consent I wanted to do nothing, that your good deed might not be by compulsion, as it were, but voluntary.

II. Key Summary

• Paul calls himself "a prisoner of Christ Jesus" and, with Timothy, writes to Philemon, Apphia, Archippus, and the church in Philemon's house (vv. 1-3).

• Paul thanks God for Philemon in his prayers, having heard of his love and faith; the hearts of the saints have been refreshed by him (vv. 4-7).

• Paul says he could boldly command Philemon, but for love's sake he appeals to him for Onesimus, his son begotten in his chains. Paul sends Onesimus back; he wished to keep him, but wanted to do nothing without Philemon's consent (vv. 8-14).

III. Passage Analysis

He Could Command, but He Chose to Ask

> Paul does not use his standing as an apostle to require Philemon to accept the runaway slave Onesimus; he only uses the tone of a request, showing that this request comes from love. [1]

Paul says he "might be very bold in Christ to command" (v. 8), yet what he actually says is "for love's sake I rather appeal to you" (v. 9). He wished to keep Onesimus too, but he sends him back first and does not decide for Philemon (vv. 12-14).

He sets aside his right to command and leaves the decision with Philemon, because "an act that comes from love is not forced, but willing" [1].

Finally Living Up to His Name

> It is significant to note that Paul claims that in Christ the useless person has been made useful. [2]

The name Onesimus means "profitable," and Paul says plainly that he "once was unprofitable to you, but now is profitable to you and to me" (v. 11), a play on his name [2]. The turning point is that he became the son Paul had "begotten while in my chains" (v. 10): Paul led him to faith in Jesus during his imprisonment [2]. In verse 12, Paul calls him "my own heart."

The man who once did not match his own name now lives up to it, and Paul calls him his own heart.

IV. Reflection Question

If you were the leader of a group project and could simply command a teammate to change their part your way, what would you do? If they changed it only because you forced them, what would you think?

Paul was also in a position to command. He "might be very bold in Christ to command," yet "for love's sake" he appealed, and without Philemon's consent he "wanted to do nothing" about keeping Onesimus (vv. 8-9, 13-14), "that your good deed might not be by compulsion, as it were, but voluntary."

References

[1] Chinese Christian Bible Study Resources (ccbiblestudy.org), Philemon 1 Notes (Chi Dao Study Bible Commentary, Phlm 8-10, 14), https://www.ccbiblestudy.org/New%20Testament/57Philem/57GT01.htm

[2] Enduring Word, David Guzik (including a quotation from Barclay, Phlm 10-11), https://enduringword.com/bible-commentary/philemon-1/